

B1

GRAMMAR LESSON · MODAL VERBS

Can vs Could

Ability now and in the past, polite requests and possibility.

Can - Could Farkı

QUICK UNDERSTANDING

Can ve **could** aynı fiilin (yetenek/olasılık bildiren modal) iki farklı formu gibi görünse de, aralarında iki önemli fark vardır: (1) **can** ŞİMDİKİ zamanda, **could** ise GEÇMİŞTE genel bir yeteneği anlatır; (2) rica ve izin isterken **could**, **can**'e göre daha KİBAR ve daha resmi bir ton taşır.

The Structure

Formula

Subject + can + V1 (şimdiki zaman)

Subject + could + V1 (geçmiş zaman / kibar rica / olasılık)

Olumsuz: can't/cannot (şimdi), couldn't (geçmiş). Soru: Can/Could + özne + V1?

Affirmative / Negative / Question

AFFIRMATIVE

I can play chess.

He could run fast as a child.

NEGATIVE

I can't play chess well.

She couldn't drive until last year.

QUESTION

Can you play chess?

Could you play chess as a child?

Word Order

Özne — can/could — fiil (V1)

- She **can** speak three languages. — Üç dil konuşabiliyor.
- **Could** you repeat that, please? — Bunu tekrar eder misiniz lütfen?

How It Works

When do we use it?

- **can**: şimdiki zamanda yetenek, izin veya olasılık — I can drive a car.
- **could**: geçmişte genel/süregelen bir yetenek — I could read before I started school.
- **could (kibarlık)**: rica ve izin isterken **can**'e göre daha nazik, daha resmi bir ton — Could you open the window, please?
- **could (olasılık)**: şimdi/gelecek için ihtimal — The weather could change tomorrow.

When DON'T we use it?

Şimdiki zaman cümlesinde "could" KULLANMA, geçmiş cümlede "can" KULLANMA — zaman uyumsuzluğu en sık yapılan hatadır.

✗ I can swim when I was young. → ✓ I could swim when I was young.

can ve could'u aynı kibarlık seviyesinde DÜŞÜNME — resmi bir ricada sadece "can" kullanmak biraz kaba/doğrudan durabilir.

☒ Can you pass the report? (gündelik, doğrudan) → ✓ Could you pass the report, please? (daha kibar)

Short Answers

Kısa cevap kullanılan modalla verilir: Yes, I can. / No, I can't. — Yes, I could. / No, I couldn't.

Not: Kibar bir ricaya (Could you...?) genelde "Sure.", "Of course." gibi tam cevaplar verilir, sadece "Yes, I could." tuhaf kaçır.

Türkçe Mantığı

Zihninde şu sırayla ilerle:

TÜRKÇEDE NE DEMEK İSTİYORUM? → "Yüzebiliyorum." (şimdi) vs. "Çocukken yüzebilirdim." (geçmişte) → ZAMAN NE? → Şimdiki zaman → can; geçmiş zaman → could → YOKSA KİBAR BİR RİCA MI? → "Yardım eder misiniz?" gibi resmi bir istekte could, can'den daha naziktir. → CÜMLE → "I can swim." / "I could swim when I was five." / "Could you help me, please?"

Examples

CAN — ŞİMDİKİ YETENEK

- I can cook Italian food quite well. — İtalyan yemeği epey iyi pişirebiliyorum.
- Can you hear that noise? — O sesi duyabiliyor musun?
- He can't come to the phone right now. — Şu anda telefona gelemiyor.

COULD — GEÇMİŞ YETENEK

- When I was younger, I could stay up all night. — Gençken bütün gece uyanık kalabilirdim.
- My grandmother could sew beautiful dresses. — Büyükanem çok güzel elbiseler dikebilirdi.
- We couldn't afford a car back then. — O zamanlar araba almaya gücümüz yetmezdi.

KIBARLIK FARKI: COULD YOU VS CAN YOU

- Can you pass me the remote? — Kumandayı uzatır mısın? (gündelik, samimi)
- Could you pass me the remote, please? — Kumandayı uzatır mısınız lütfen? (daha kibar)
- Could I ask you something important? — Size önemli bir şey sorabilir miyim? (kibar, resmi)
- It could rain later, so take an umbrella. — Sonra yağmur yağabilir, o yüzden şemsiye al. (olasılık)
- Could you explain this again, please? — Bunu tekrar açıkla lütfen?
- I could hear music from next door all night. — Bütün gece yan daireden müzik duyabiliyordum.

Compare & Notice

Compare With

Could (Genel Geçmiş Yetenek) Bir zaman diliminde SÜREGELEN, genel bir yeteneği anlatır — belirli bir olayı değil. I could speak German when I lived in Berlin.	Was Able To / Managed To Belirli, TEK SEFERLİK, genelde zor bir durumda elde edilen bir başarıyı anlatır. I managed to fix the car by myself.
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→ Yetenek belirten modallere git

Karar Şeması (Decision Guide)

Soru: Şimdiki zamandan mı, geçmişten mi bahsediyorsun, yoksa kibar bir rica mı ediyorsun?

ŞİMDİKİ ZAMAN YETENEĞİ can + V1 → "I can cook."	GEÇMİŞTEKİ GENEL YETENEK could + V1 → "I could cook when I was ten."	KIBAR RICA / İZİN Could you...? / Could I...? → daha resmi ve nazik
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Common Mistakes

✗ I can swim very well when I was seven.	✓ I could swim very well when I was seven.
WHY? Cümlede geçmiş zaman belirteci (when I was seven) var, bu yüzden can değil could kullanılmalıdır — zaman uyumu önemlidir.	
✗ Last year I couldn't pass the exam, but I studied hard and finally could pass it.	✓ Last year I couldn't pass the exam, but I studied hard and finally managed to pass it.
WHY? Tek seferlik, zor bir başarı için could değil managed to/was able to kullanılır (bkz. Yetenek Belirten Modaller konusu).	
✗ Could you please to close the door?	✓ Could you please close the door?
WHY? could'dan sonra "to" gelmez, doğrudan V1 gelir.	
✗ Can you help me? (çok resmi bir iş mektubunda)	✓ Could you help me, please? (çok resmi bir iş mektubunda)
WHY? can ve could aynı kibarlık seviyesinde değildir; resmi yazışmalarda could daha uygun ve nazik bir seçimdir.	
✗ You could have tell me earlier! (şikayet/pişmanlık)	✓ You could have told me earlier!
WHY? "could have" bir gerçekleşmemiş geçmiş fırsatı anlatır ve ardından her zaman V3 (past participle) gelir, V1 değil.	

Practice

Name: _____

Date: _____

Score: _____ / 19

PART A · QUICK CHECK

1. I _____ swim very well when I was seven.

a) am able

b) could

c) will can

d) can

2. Find the mistake and correct it.

Could you please ^A to close ^B the door? ^C

Correction: _____

3. _____ you help me, please? (to a stranger, politely)

a) Could

b) May you

c) Must

d) Can to

PART B · PRACTICE

4. I _____ drive a car, so I'll take you home.

a) can

b) can to

c) could last year

d) am can

5. I studied hard and finally _____ pass the exam.

a) could

b) managed to

c) could to

d) can

6. The weather _____ change tomorrow. Take a jacket. (could / can't)

7. Find the mistake and correct it.

I ^A can ^B read before I started school. ^C

Correction: _____

8. You want to ask your boss if you can leave early.

What do you say?

a) Can I to leave early today?

b) Could I leaving early today?

c) Could I leave a bit early today?

d) May I to leave early today?

9. "When I was young, I couldn't swim." What does it mean?

a) I wasn't able to swim then.

b) I didn't want to swim.

c) I wasn't allowed to swim.

d) I can't swim now.

10. Which sentence is correct?

a) Last year I couldn't pass the exam.

b) Last year I could not to pass the exam.

c) Last year I can't pass the exam.

d) Last year I couldn't passed the exam.

PART C · FINAL CHECK

11. My little brother _____ read yet.
a) can't b) doesn't can c) couldn't yet d) can not to
12. The fire spread fast, but everyone _____ escape.
a) could to b) can c) could d) managed to
13. _____ you speak any other languages? (can)
14. Find the mistake and correct it.
Can you ^A lend me some ^B money, sir? (very polite) ^C
Correction: _____
15. It _____ be very hot in Antalya in July.
a) cans b) could yesterday c) can to d) can
16. Your teacher asks why you didn't finish the test.
What do you say?
a) I could not answered the last question.
b) I couldn't to answer the last question.
c) I couldn't answer the last question.
d) I can't answered the last question.
17. "That could be the answer." What does it mean?
a) Someone is able to answer.
b) It was the answer in the past.
c) It is definitely the answer.
d) It's possible that it is the answer.
18. When she was a child, she _____ play the violin beautifully.
a) could b) is able c) can d) managed
19. Rewrite more politely: "Can you send me the file?"
_____ send me the file?

Answer Key

Kısa açıklamalar, her cevabın hangi kurala dayandığını gösterir.

PART A · QUICK CHECK

1. **b) could** — Geçmişte yetenek → could.
2. **B — to close → close** — could + V1.
3. **a) Could** — Kibar rica → Could you...?

PART B · PRACTICE

4. **a) can** — Şimdiki yetenek → can.
5. **b) managed to** — Geçmişte tek seferlik başarı → managed to.
6. **could** — Olasılık → could.
7. **B — can → could** — Geçmişte genel yetenek → could.
8. **c) Could I leave a bit early today?** — Kibar izin → Could I...?
9. **a) I wasn't able to swim then.** — couldn't → geçmişte yeteneksizlik.
10. **a) Last year I couldn't pass the exam.** — Geçmiş olumsuz → couldn't + V1.

PART C · FINAL CHECK

11. **a) can't** — Şimdi → can't.
12. **d) managed to** — Tek seferlik başarı → managed to (ya da was able to).
13. **Can** — Şimdiki yetenek sorusu: Can you...?
14. **A — Can you → Could you** — Resmi, kibar rica → Could you...?
15. **d) can** — Genel olasılık/doğru → can.
16. **c) I couldn't answer the last question.** — Geçmiş olumsuz → couldn't + V1.
17. **d) It's possible that it is the answer.** — could → olasılık.
18. **a) could** — Geçmişte genel yetenek → could.
19. **Could you send me the file?** — Daha kibar → Could you...?

Bu dersin interaktif versiyonu (anında geri bildirimli alıştırma):

<https://abonlinenglish.school/grammar/b1/can-vs-could>